“Race” in Portuguese: Representations of Race in Brazilian Literature

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Introduction

- In Brazil, notions about the history of race have shaped representations of Negros and Mulattos in literature and cinema. Representations of Afro-descendents changed from the middle of the nineteenth and twentieth century. Three periods are identified: the Emancipation Period (1850-1888); the Whitening Period (1890-1914); and the emergence of a Racial Democracy and Military Dictatorship (1930-1980).
- The Brazilian elite in each period strove to paint a portrait of harmonious racial relations, but development of an Afro-Brazilian consciousness began to emerge, paralleling the racial democracy theory.
- In the nineteenth century, racial mixing was seen as leading to degeneration and to Brazil’s backwardness. Subsequently, an ideology of “racial democracy” was followed by a denouncement of racism in Brazil.
- This study demonstrates how cultural representations of Afro-Brazilians are related to ideologies of race and concerns of the elite regarding apparently high rates of miscegenation.

Background

- Brazil had the largest slave population in the world.
- Slaves mainly worked in mining and sugar cane sectors.
- 35% of captured Africans involved in the Transatlantic Slave Trade were transported to Brazil.
- Approximately three million Africans reached Brazil.
- Slavery ended May 13, 1888; Brazil was the last country to abolish slavery in the New World.
- Brazil has the second largest Black population in the world, with Nigeria being the largest.

Significance of the Study

Studies of “race” in Brazil have been the domain of the social sciences. Representation of “race” must be taken into account in cultural products and literature. Dominant ideologies of “race” varied with time and location. The significance of this study is to provide another perspective of analyzing racial constructions through Brazilian literature and cinema.

Method

When conducting research in the humanities, one is limited to using secondary sources. I was often confronted with blind spots; often relying heavily on what was previously said about the theme of race in Brazil. To answer my research questions , I analyzed books, articles, and film that related to my topic. In contrast to other fields, I was required to step outside the realm of literature to analyze what historians and social scientists previously discovered.

Research questions:

- How are Afro-Brazilians represented in literature and cinema?
- What role did historical events and changing attitudes regarding miscegenation play in representations of Afro-Brazilians?

To answer my research question I used:

- Usage of interdisciplinary sources (history, literature, and film).
- Usage of library databases.

Literature Review

Emancipation Period-Whitening Period: Literature and Ideologies Concerning Miscegenation.

- In *Dando nome às diferenças (Giving Names to the Differences)* Lília Schwarz proposes that studies of the racial phenomenon begins with systemization of differences at the end of the 19th century, when the Brazilian population was seen as a “laboratory” for racial experiences. Perceptions about Brazil’s mixed populations were seen as a “spectacle.”
- In *I’inégalité des Races Humaines,* published in 1856, Joseph Arthur de Gobineau defended his thesis that Brazilian society is “unviable” because it possessed large populations of “mixed” persons.
- *O negro na ficção brasileira: meio século de história literária (The Negro in Brazilian Fiction: Half a Century of Literary History)* accompanied literature that includes perspectives of White ,Black, and Abolitionists writers. In this book , Afro-Brazilians identified themselves through poetry that went beyond the stereotypical roles they occupied in history.
- In *The Negro in Brazilian Literature,* Raymond Sawyer followed the Black trajectory in Brazilian literature from the Iberian Peninsula. until the Naturalist Period. This book represented Negros in a variety of ways.
- *O bom –crioulo (The Good Nigger),* is a Brazilian romance highlighting homosexual relations between slaves and masters which described miscegenation in a different context. This novel showed that “miscegenation” went beyond heterosexual connotations in Brazil.

Racial Democracy-Military Dictatorship: Ideologies and Brazilian Cinema

- “Race, Class, and Color Behind Brazil’s ‘Racial Democracy’”, Sergio Guimarães’ focused on culture, rather than race as a justification for social inequalities. The notion of color was replaced with race., therefore disparities suffered by Afro-Brazilians are effects related to their social-economic position.
- *Casa-grande e Senzala, (The Masters and the Slaves)* published in 1933 by Gilberto Freyre, discussed the formation of Brazilian Society. The “Casa-Grande” (Big house) refers to the landlord’s residence in sugar plantations, where towns were owned and managed by one man. The “Senzala” refers to the dwelling of the Black working class, where they originally worked as slaves, and later as servants. In Freyre’s opinion, the architecture of the casa-grande, was an expression of a patriarchal society. The author refutes the idea that Brazil would have an "inferior race" because of racial-mixing, pointing to the positive elements that permeate Brazilian cultural formation because of miscegenation .
- *Xica da Silva*, based on the novel *Memórias do Distrito de Diamantina,* by João Felicio dos Santos. This film was written and directed during the military dictatorship when many Afro-Brazilians appeared in film within the context of slavery, but with socio-economic power through unions with affluent Portuguese figures.
- Although racism was not the focus of this study, understanding racial dynamics in Brazil contributes equally to the understanding of race representation in Brazil. From the end of the 19th century until the mid-20th century, dynamics about race and its representations began to shift. Afro-descendents began to think critically about the issue of race. The book, *Race in another America: the Significance of Skin Color in Brazil*, encompasses social issues concerning race and racial representations during the 20th century.
- In *Negros na sociedade e na cultura Brasileiras III : Construindo uma nova cosciência (Brazilians in the Brazilian Society and Culture III: Constructing a New Conscience,)* Sarah Taleb Rassi, highlights the development of Black consciousness through poetry, where Afro-Brazilians began to think critically about miscegenation and the identity crises they suffered in their communities.



Photo credits to: Miguel de Cabrera, *De Español y Negra, Mulato,* http://en.18dao.net/Map/Brazil

Discussion

Emancipation-Whitening Period (1850-1914)

- The importance of this period is to gain an understanding of how “race” is constructed in Brazil in contrast to different ideologies of race during slavery in the United States.
- The first half of this period marked resistance to racial mixing, while the second half regarded miscegenation as a “corrector” to Brazilian blackness.
- Miscegenation allowed the Brazilian elite to speculate Brazil’s future in terms of economics and political power.

Racial Democracy-Military Dictatorship (1930-1980)

- This period illustrated how the Brazilian elite perpetuated the idea of a racial paradise through a history of miscegenation, as a way to compete globally.
- This marked the beginning of Black movements that rebuke the discourse about a racial democracy.
- The rise of Embrafilme (Brazilian cinegraphic movement that incorporated Blacks) during the military dictatorship reinforced the belief of Brazil as a racial democracy.